A Kingdom Divided, Prophets Sent

1 Kings 12; 17–19; 2 Kings 17

The big idea: After Solomon, the kingdom split, and the north turned to golden calves and Baal. God did not walk away. He sent prophets, above all Elijah, who called the people to choose the LORD. Israel would not listen and fell to Assyria in 722 BC. Finally God sent his Son, the last and greatest Prophet.

Before you meet: Read

1 Kings 12:1–20, 25–30 | 1 Kings 17:1–16 | 1 Kings 18:17–39 | 1 Kings 19:1–18 | 2 Kings 17:6–18; Hebrews 1:1–2

Open (5 minutes)

Think of a time someone warned you about something and you did not listen. What happened?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Behold your _____, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt." *(1 Kings 12:28)*

"And the _____ brought him bread and meat in the morning, and bread and meat in the evening." *(1 Kings 17:6)*

"How long will you go _____ between two different opinions? If the LORD is God, follow him." *(1 Kings 18:21)*

"The LORD, he is _____; the LORD, he is God." *(1 Kings 18:39)*

"And after the fire the sound of a low _____." *(1 Kings 19:12)*

"In these last days he has spoken to us by his _____." *(Hebrews 1:2)*

Discuss

1. Jeroboam made golden calves so his people would not go to Jerusalem. What convenient substitutes for God do people create today? *1 Kings 12:26–30*

2. Baal was the god of rain, crops, and success. What do people trust for security and success today? *1 Kings 16:30–33; 17:1*

3. Elijah asked how long the people would limp between two opinions. Where are you trying to keep one foot in each world? *1 Kings 18:21*

4. Right after his greatest victory, Elijah wanted to die. What does God's gentle care for him teach you about seasons of deep discouragement? *1 Kings 19:3–18*

5. God sent prophet after prophet, and Israel would not listen. Why is it so hard to hear warnings? *2 Kings 17:13–14*

6. Hebrews says God once spoke by the prophets but now has spoken by his Son. What changes if Jesus is God's final word to you? *Hebrews 1:1–2; Matthew 21:33–41*

Apply this week

Name your Baal: the thing you look to for security or success in place of God. Ask God for grace to let go of one divided loyalty this week. If you are worn out like Elijah, rest, eat, and reach out to another believer for prayer, and if you have ever prayed his prayer to die, tell someone today.

Memory verse

"Long ago, at many times and in many ways, God spoke to our fathers by the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son."

Hebrews 1:1–2

Pray

Confess the places where you limp between two opinions. Thank God for his patience in sending prophet after prophet, and for keeping a people for himself by grace. Thank Jesus, God's final Word, who took the fire of judgment for sinners.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 16

A Kingdom Divided, Prophets Sent

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read 1 Kings 18:20–39 aloud together. Then read 1 Kings 19:9–18.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 3, 4, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the One Kingdom Becomes Two timeline and the Prophets God Sent table in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 17 (2 Kings 25; Jeremiah 29:1–14; Daniel 1 and 6).

Main points to land

1. In 931 BC the kingdom split into Israel in the north and Judah in the south. The north began with golden calves and never turned back (1 Kings 12:28).
2. Elijah's name means my God is the LORD. On Carmel God answered by fire, and the people confessed, The LORD, he is God (1 Kings 18:39).
3. God cared gently for his discouraged prophet and kept a remnant of seven thousand, chosen by grace (1 Kings 19:4–18; Romans 11:5).
4. God sent prophet after prophet, but Israel would not listen, and Assyria destroyed the north in 722 BC (2 Kings 17:6, 13–14).
5. Finally God sent his Son. Jesus is the final Prophet, God's last word, who took the fire of judgment on himself (Hebrews 1:1–2; Matthew 21:37).

Core doctrine to teach

Repentance CORE DOCTRINE 16 OF 26

Repentance is turning from sin to God. It is more than feeling sorry, and it is itself a gift of God's grace (Acts 11:18), not a payment for his mercy. It means seeing your sin as God sees it, grieving over it, trusting his mercy in Christ, and turning to a new way of life. The prophets called Israel to it again and again, and Jesus calls us to it today. *Joel 2:12–13; Isaiah 55:6–7; Luke 15:20; Acts 3:19; 2 Corinthians 7:10*

Answer key (Observe)

1. gods
2. ravens
3. limping
4. God

5. whisper
6. Son

Questions people will ask

Why did Elijah kill the prophets of Baal? Should Christians do that to false teachers?
No. Israel was a nation under God's direct rule, and its covenant law treated a prophet who led people to other gods as a capital traitor (Deuteronomy 13:5). Like the conquest, that belonged to Israel's unique place in history. The church fights false teaching with the truth, never with the sword (2 Corinthians 10:4; John 18:36).

Is it wrong for a Christian to feel like Elijah, wanting to die?
Elijah was a man of great faith, and he still prayed to die. God did not shame him. He gave him sleep, food, his presence, and a friend. Treat this question gently. Encourage anyone who has felt this way to tell a pastor, a friend, or a doctor, and in the U.S. to call or text 988.

What happened to the ten northern tribes?
Assyria scattered many of them across its empire and resettled the land with foreigners, who mixed with the Israelites left behind and became the Samaritans (2 Kings 17:6, 24). But not all were lost. Some from the north joined Judah, and the New Testament still speaks of the twelve tribes (Luke 2:36; James 1:1). God kept a remnant.

Was John the Baptist really Elijah?
John said he was not Elijah come back to life (John 1:21), but Jesus said he fulfilled the promise of Malachi 4:5 (Matthew 11:14), because he came in the spirit and power of Elijah (Luke 1:17) to prepare the way for the Lord.

Closing prayer

Father, you did not walk away from your people. You sent prophet after prophet, and in these last days you have spoken to us by your Son. Forgive us for limping between two opinions. Care for the weary among us as you cared for Elijah. Help us listen to Jesus, your final Word, who took the fire of judgment for us. The LORD, he is God. Amen.